

THE PAYSON MORNING SCROLL

MADE EXCLUSIVELY FOR THE MOGOLLON’S HEARTH GUESTS

“All the news worth knowing before the mead hall opens.”

THE GREYBEARDS OF HIGH HROTHGAR — PUBLISHER & PROPRIETOR

PAYSON, ARIZONA · FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 25, 2026 · Morning Edition — Vol. 2609, No. 25 · PRICE: ONE SEPTIM



Henny the chicken, lounging on the deck and shading her eyes from the warm sun.

SKIES O’ER THE HOLD

78° / 57°

Mostly sunny

Sunrise 6:15 AM · Sunset 6:17 PM

Mostly sunny, 82/60

AROUND THE HOLD · THE WEEK AHEAD

Highland Games and the 72nd Fair: A Weekend Fit for the Hold



By the Dude — Payson, Ariz.



Caber-tossing, bagpipers, and merry crowds at the Prescott Highland Games on Watson Lake — with the 72nd Northern Gila County Fair marching right behind.

HAIL, FRIENDS OF THE HEARTH! — The sun climbs warm and gold over the ponderosas this Friday, and by tonight's full moon the roads will be merry indeed: the Prescott Highland Games return to Watson Lake, the 72nd Northern Gila County Fair opens its gates in Payson, and the Payson Town Council has heard a bold new dream for Main Street. Strap on your boots, traveler — the Hold is celebrating this week.

HAPPENING IN THE HOLDS TODAY



Prescott

- **Flashback LIVE** — live music, 8:00 PM tonight, Whiskey River Tavern, 214 S. Montezuma St.
- **4th Friday Art Walk** — downtown galleries hold extended hours (about 5–8 PM); 'Tis Art Center & Gallery, 105 S Cortez St.



Sedona

- **Frequency Friday** — meditation, BioCharger & sound bath, 5:45 PM, 1730 W State Rte 89A, \$25 (free for members).



Show Low

- **Country Western Dance & Lessons** — 7:00 PM tonight, 1105 Old Hwy 160, Show Low.

THE DAYS AHEAD

• Saturday, Sept. 26

- **Prescott Highland Games & Celtic Faire** (Sat–Sun) — Watson Lake Park, Prescott; Sat 9 AM–5 PM, Sun 9 AM–4 PM; \$15 adults, kids under 5 free. Heavy athletics, pipe bands, Highland dance, scotch tasting, axe throwing, and vendors from the Prescott Area Celtic Society's two-decade-running games.
- **NoCo Harvest Fest (7th annual)** — 2–8 PM, 222 N Cortez St, downtown Prescott; free entry. Local makers and vintage finds, good food, cold drinks, live music, and a ticketed chef's Taste of the Season food journey.
- **Forest of Shadows** — 6–9 PM, Prescott Valley Town Center Turf Park, 2980 N Park Ave; free one-night immersive walk-through with glowing gardens, a witch's cottage, magical creatures, an AR scavenger hunt, costume contests, and a butterbeer station.
- **Taste at the Bridge** — 5 PM, Tonto Natural Bridge State Park (between Pine and Payson). Annual fundraiser of the Friends of Tonto Natural Bridge: food, live music, auctions, and wine and beer tastings; \$100 a seat, proceeds support park conservation.

• Sunday, Sept. 27

- **Sedona Community Farmers Market** — 8 AM–noon, Wells Fargo lot, 2201 W State Rte 89A, West Sedona; seasonal harvest and artisan goods with live music.

• Monday, Sept. 28

- **Open Mic Night: Music with a Purpose** — 4 PM, THAT Brewery & Pub, 3270 N Hwy 87, Pine. Open mic hosted by members of the fuel-reduction team; tips benefit Pine Strawberry Fuel Reduction.

• Tuesday, Sept. 29

- **Trail Day Volunteer Build, Pine** — 7 AM–12 PM, Pine off Hwy 87. Pine Strawberry Fuel Reduction's volunteer trail-building day — clear brush, move rocks, shape trail; tools provided, bring water, gloves, and sturdy shoes.

• Thursday, Oct. 1

- **Northern Gila County Fair & B.U.C.K.L.E. Festival opens** (Oct 1–3), Payson Event Center. The 72nd annual — bull riding, ranch rodeo, barrel racing, mutton bustin', junior livestock auction, fiddle festival, live music, and a mini-carnival.
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QUESTS OF THE HEARTH

Quests awaiting:

- ☐ **Design & prep the torch sconces** — Measure the flame bulb and socket, settle the sconce design, and slice in PETG — the Arizona sun eats PLA. Due Saturday, Sept. 26.

Due Saturday: finish the torch-sconce designs, or the Hearth's doorways stay unlit.



Designs for the Hearth's door torches, drawn up for the forge.

WORD FROM THE PAYSON HOLD



The Payson Town Council held its regular meeting on Wednesday, Sept. 23, from 4:00 to 6:00 PM. No council meeting is scheduled in the next seven days; the next regular meeting is Wednesday, Oct. 14, at 4:00 PM in the Town Council Chambers, 303 N Beeline Highway.

The headline item: the council heard a new Main Street proposal from Jim Hammett of White Mountain Advisory, a Show Low-based consulting firm — the only firm to answer Payson's request for proposals to update years of Main Street master plans. The pitch would turn long-struggling Main Street into an arts, cultural and business center: an arts district with a walkable commercial district, tourism draws, and a connection to a rebuilt event center, American Gulch, and the proposed Green Valley Parkway extension. The corridor would run from the Sawmill shopping center on Highway 87 to Green Valley Park, with room for musicians, artists, festivals and youth programs beside a business district built to generate sales-tax revenue. Hammett told the council the difference this time is political and community will, and that the firm would research each step with the community before projects advance. Read the full story in the [Payson Roundup](#) (Sept. 22, by Peter Aleshire).

The council did not vote on the proposal. Town staff will keep working with the consultants to refine the plan and develop a price estimate; Town Manager Darren Coldwell said the council would see the consultants two or three more times before any decision. Members applauded the presentation and noted the town's groundwork — key parcel acquisitions, nearly complete flood-control engineering for American Gulch, and parallel event-center plans. The meeting's [recording](#) is on the town's YouTube channel; the written agenda and minutes were not yet posted when we went to press.

MERCHANT OF THE HOLD

Explore the Attic · Payson



Fresh from the merchant's kitchen.

A true treasure-hunt of an antique shop, 30 years on Highway 260 and room after room of wonders — vintage sewing machines, vinyl records, glassware, jewelry, garden décor, and the oddities of a small army of dealer booths. There is even a secret bar tucked in somewhere, and an outdoor yard of rusty garden art worth a wander all its own.

“Nice antique shop with many rooms of interesting items. You can easily spend an hour here looking at items from the past. They have a good selection of vintage vinyl music albums.” — [TripAdvisor review \(Jul 2026\)](#)

800 E State Highway 260,
Payson | Open daily 10 AM–5
PM | (928) 474-2897 |
Moderate prices | Good-to-
know: open Mondays, when
many Payson shops take the
day off. · [their website](#)

Why the Hearth sends you:

Because the Hearth's guests
deserve a proper rummage —
a shop with a secret bar and
thirty years of treasures is the
Hold's kind of dungeon.

STORIES AROUND THE RIM

HE WAS HERE TEN MINUTES AGO



The Hold stares skyward at Helgen's word — while the
Dragonborn vanishes down the road.

A rider came through Pine at dawn with word from a hold far to the north, and it is a tale to curl your toes.

In a town called Helgen, the lawbreakers were lined up for the axe — a hooded prisoner among them — when the sky went black and something roared overhead. The rider swears, hand on his heart, that it was a DRAGON.

The Hold gathered by the lodge in a proper fright. A dragon! In our skies! Folks were white as Gus's flour — until somebody, and the name is lost to history, let loose a truly enormous fart, and the whole scary moment passed in a gale of laughter.

Everyone blamed Earl on the spot. Now Earl was three pine-stands away picking berries at the time, and he is DEEPLY, dignifiedly offended. Gus, meanwhile, has gone suspiciously quiet about where exactly he was standing. Nobody admits a thing. Accusations are flying. The true culprit stays anonymous. Forever.

And the hooded prisoner? "Gone," the rider says. "Walked out of the dust and the shouting" — and here the rider went pale and would not finish the sentence.

He was here not ten minutes ago, the Dragonborn was, the bards say. And now he's gone.

THE LIVING HAT RACK



Earl, dignity intact, wearing the neighborhood's hats.

That dang ol' Jethro is at it again.

It started when Earl dozed off beside the woodpile, minding his own noble business, and Jethro had himself a revelation: those enormous antlers, he declared (loudly, to nobody), would make the finest hat rack the forest has ever seen.

Earl woke to find Gus's flour-dusted baker's cap looped on one tine and Mabel's sunbonnet — Mabel's! she had only set it down for half a second — dangling from another. Jethro, beaming, was lining Flurry's bottle-cap collection along the brow tines like a row of tiny goblets.

Earl looked at Jethro. Then, with tremendous dignity, he froze mid-step and decided to simply not move, on the theory that the nonsense would pass.

It did not pass. Gus arrived with a fresh pie, saw his own hat on an elk, and dropped the pie loudly — as he does. Henny, unbothered, began pecking at it with professional interest. Flurry landed sideways in the leaf litter and pretended he meant to.

Mabel sighed like it was her job, collected her bonnet, and declared Earl "the only piece of furniture in this forest that judges you back."

An hour later Earl sneezed. Everything slid. Jethro caught an upside-down pie tin on his own head and declared the rack a triumph. Earl stalked off into the pines, dignified, one pie tin still hooked on an antler, which he refused to acknowledge for the rest of the day.